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Ceuta Slowly Recovers After Its Largest Migrant Surge in History, but the Wounds Are Still Fresh

After tens of thousands of migrants crossed the border within just two days, this small Spanish city on the northern tip of Africa is gradually returning to its routine. Yet the debate over who should be blamed for the tragedy that left dozens dead is far from over.

By VokaMedia Reporter

Ceuta, Spain — Over the weekend, Ceuta no longer felt as tense as it had in the days before. Shops reopened, and residents and tourists alike began filling the cafes and restaurants of the small city, a Spanish exclave in North Africa. But beneath the seemingly calm surface, residents' unease had not fully faded.

On Thursday and Friday the previous week, around 50,000 to 60,000 people, mostly young men, crossed into Ceuta without authorization. The surge swelled the population of a city that normally holds around 84,000 residents by more than half in just two days.

Spanish authorities said on Sunday that at least 72 migrants had died during the incident. Some drowned, while others were killed in a stampede while crushing through a breakwater that had briefly served as one of the entry points. Guardia Civil vessels, Spain's coast guard, were still searching the waters around the city for bodies yet to be found.

By the end of the weekend, most of the migrants who had entered had already returned to Morocco. Even so, some chose to remain in the hills surrounding the city or tried to blend in with local residents.

The incident sparked debate among residents over its cause and over who bears the most responsibility. A number of residents argued that the young arrivals themselves were not really to blame, and pointed instead to border authorities accused of failing to control the situation from the outset. Others, however, blamed the surge of migrants for forcing their way in all at once and in such large numbers.

Political tension also colored the mood in the city. Far-right Spanish politician Alvise Pérez, who called for migrants to be deported, was briefly trapped inside a bar after being surrounded by a crowd opposing his presence, before police eventually escorted him away. One of the

counter-protesters, Noor Ahmed, a 20-year-old student from Ceuta, argued that the presence of figures like Pérez amid the humanitarian crisis amounted to nothing more than exploiting the situation for political gain.

Pope Leo XIV also weighed in on the events. He expressed concern over the situation in Ceuta and voiced hope that a peaceful and just solution could soon be found. Migration has indeed been one of Pope Leo XIV's key concerns, having recently visited the Canary Islands, one of Europe's largest migrant entry points.

The incident in Ceuta has reignited a long-running debate over migration policy in Europe, particularly on how countries in the region should respond to large-scale surges of arrivals without sacrificing either humanitarian principles or the sense of safety among local residents.

Tags: migration, Ceuta, Spain, humanitarian crisis, society, Europe

Caption: Illustration. Guardia Civil officers patrol the Ceuta coastline following the migrant surge. Source: Pexels